

WFH Woes

MY FAVOURITE SAYING GOES, “FIND A JOB YOU LOVE AND YOU’LL NEVER WORK A DAY IN YOUR LIFE”. Thus, when I joined Digit in January 2003, my dream had come true. I was the type of employee who would wade through a flood, or sleep in the office because travelling back home seemed pointless. In fact I once spent 15 days in office (I was developing a new DVD interface back in the day), without going home. My wife sent me fresh clothes via colleagues who lived nearby, and I bathed using the mug and bucket in the loo! Not once in that time did I imagine that I would be the one wanting to work from home...

Then in 2010 or so, I started feeling exactly that way. While my passion had got me a lot of success and personal growth, and I kept getting promoted until I was actually running Digit... it all took me away from the things that I loved. Which was writing and fiddling around with technology. There were always problems to solve, guidance to give, and a lot of handing over of actual work to others while I played the role of the boss. And it was boring as heck!

My working from home started with a need to get away from it all, and just be able to sit down and write, or read, learn and tinker. At first it was a day a week spent at home, then two, and eventually, I was pretty much only coming to the office three or four days a month. I was writing a lot more, I was brimming with ideas again, and I felt good! As a bonus, a few people in the team rose to the occasion and took charge of handling the mini crises of every day. Long term readers will remember those people having columns in these beginning pages, and Mithun was one of them.

I decided to move to Australia in 2015, and a huge card was bought and signed by members of Digit past and present, ex colleagues came to bid me farewell, and Mithun even threw together a website of some sorts as a parting gift to me – which I honestly don’t even remember seeing at the time, because I’d been reduced to an emotional wreck by the thought of leaving what felt like my life’s purpose!

And then my boss asked me to just continue working, because “it’s not like you come to the office anyway,” he said. And here I

am, nearly six years after moving to Australia, still working from home. And it’s been tough!

For one thing, your family cannot help disturbing you. Just do this one thing for them... it won’t take more than 5 minutes! And if you refuse, you come across as evil and uncaring. So you drop what you’re working on and just do the 5 minute task... buy eggs and milk for breakfast tomorrow, drop the family off at the mall, or pick them up. The doorbell rings, couriers come and go, neighbours pop in, family members and friends come to visit, your son gets his finger jammed in the door and screams bloody murder... some of these you might not relate to as they’re too specific to me... but you will have your own long list of WFH Woes.

Because of all the disturbances, you end up working more hours to get the same work done, or else you work later in the night after people fall asleep because that’s when you get some quiet time. Sleep suffers. You end up eating more because at home there’s always something to munch on. Exercise goes out of the window and you start getting fat. Some others start losing weight, because they eat more home food and less junk. Overall though, you tend to get less healthy.

Even if you live alone, and don’t have too many disturbances, you end up working longer hours anyway, because there is nothing else to do. That critical work vs personal life contrast is eroded, and your family thinks you’re always working, while your boss probably thinks you’re always shirking. This is when you really have to be careful about mental health, on top of the physical health problems you might already be developing. Am I writing this because I have found a way to solve for all of this? Heck no. It’s 6 am here and I haven’t slept yet, because I’m still stuck doing everything I described above. I sit at my PC 12 hours a day, I barely get any exercise, and I’m the unhealthiest I’ve ever been.

I know people reading this column expect inspiration or knowledge, but I have none to give this time. Instead, I’d really appreciate it if those who have managed to avoid all the pitfalls of working from home can actually send me tips to learn from, which I can then share with other readers who might be struggling like me... 



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